SS112 - Final Assignment: Political Analysis

Power to the People: An Analysis of the "No Kings" Protest Movement (2025-2026)

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SS112 - Political Science and Social Change

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April 21, 2026

Word Count: 1,278

Abstract

This paper analyzes the “No Kings” protest movement in the United States from 2025 to 2026 using structuralist and constructivist frameworks. Drawing on data from the Armed Conflict Location and Event Data Project (ACLED), the World Values Survey (WVS) Wave 7, the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, and a range of journalistic and scholarly sources, it finds that large-scale mobilization emerged from a combination of declining institutional trust, heightened political polarization, and reinforcing interactions between state responses and protest activity. At the same time, the movement’s anti-monarchical framing helped unify diverse grievances into a shared democratic identity, sustaining participation across three waves totaling approximately 20 million participants. The analysis suggests that despite its scale, the movement’s long-term impact depends on its ability to translate civic mobilization into electoral and institutional change.

I. Introduction and Data Overview

In June 2025, the United States experienced one of the largest protest movements in its history. The "No Kings" movement, named in explicit opposition to what organizers framed as monarchical executive overreach, mobilized between 4 and 8 million participants across three peak protest days, repeatedly broke its own participation records, and extended to all 50 states (NoKings, 2026; Brittanica, 2026). This scale of participation raises a central question: Why did the No Kings movement emerge in three distinct waves, and expand to such a large scale? This paper examines the movement through structuralist and constructivist lenses, analyzing the material conditions that enabled protest and the meanings that sustained it.

Date	Event	General Significance
Late 2024 – Early 2025	Grievances intensified across key policy domains, including immigration enforcement, expanded executive authority, economic pressures (rising cost of living), and declining institutional responsiveness (Britannica, 2026)	Establishes structural preconditions by eroding institutional legitimacy and increasing polarization, creating a population more likely to engage in extra-institutional action
June 14, 2025	First "No Kings" protests coincide with U.S. Army 250th Anniversary Parade and President Trump's birthday (Britannica, 2026)	Functions as a symbolic trigger event, linking existing grievances to a clear narrative of executive overreach and catalyzing coordinated mobilization
June 14, 2025	Nationwide protests across approximately 2,100 sites with	Marks initial large-scale mobilization, demonstrating the capacity of pre-existing

	4–6 million participants (Britannica, 2026)	networks to rapidly coordinate mass participation
Summer 2025	Continued unrest, including immigration raids and National Guard deployments (Britannica, 2026)	Illustrates early stages of the state–protest feedback dynamic, where state responses increase grievance salience and sustain mobilization
October 18, 2025	Second wave of protests across approximately 2,700 sites with around 7 million participants (Britannica, 2026)	Represents escalation in scale and geographic diffusion, indicating that mobilization expanded beyond initial participants
Late 2025	Intensified political conflict, including government shutdown and expanded federal intervention (Britannica, 2026)	Reinforces perceptions of institutional instability and executive overreach, further activating grievance-based mobilization
March 28, 2026	Third wave of protests across approximately 3,300 sites with around 8 million participants (Britannica, 2026)	Peak mobilization phase, reflecting non-linear escalation driven by reinforcing structural dynamics
2026 (ongoing)	Continued protests without major policy or leadership change (Britannica, 2026)	Indicates limits of protest impact under existing institutional constraints and persistence of underlying structural grievances

Table 1. *Timeline of the "No Kings" Protests in the United States (2024–Present). This table outlines the sequence of structural conditions, triggering events, and successive waves of mobilization that shaped the No Kings movement. The timeline serves as a reference framework*

for the analysis that follows and is used in later sections to examine structural preconditions, feedback dynamics, and patterns of non-linear escalation.

ACLED data confirm (See Table 1) that No Kings III (March 28, 2026) set a new record with more than 2,400 single-day demonstrations nationwide (Doyle [ACLED], April 2026[1]). Across all three waves, cumulative participation reached approximately 20 million people, representing about 2.3% of the U.S. population at peak engagement (Britannica, 2026; Doyle [ACLED], April 2026).

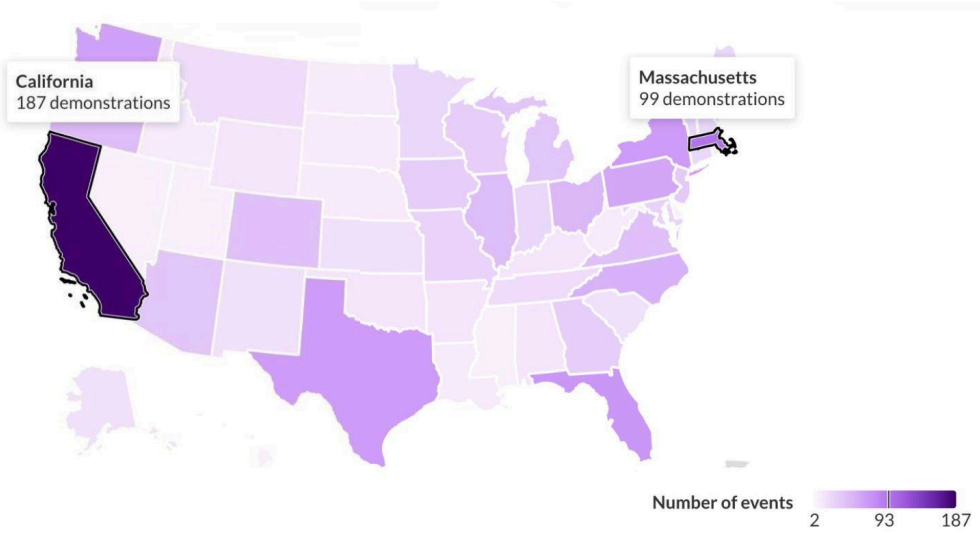


Figure 1. *ACLED choropleth map (No Kings I; June 14, 2025) showing demonstration frequency by U.S. state. Darker shading indicates higher event density. California leads with 187 demonstrations in a single-day snapshot. The near-universal geographic distribution contradicts the claim that opposition to the Trump administration was limited to coastal urban centers. (Source: ACLED, 2025)*

[1] The month is included in the citation because the reports share the same title but are published for different months and years, making them easier to distinguish.

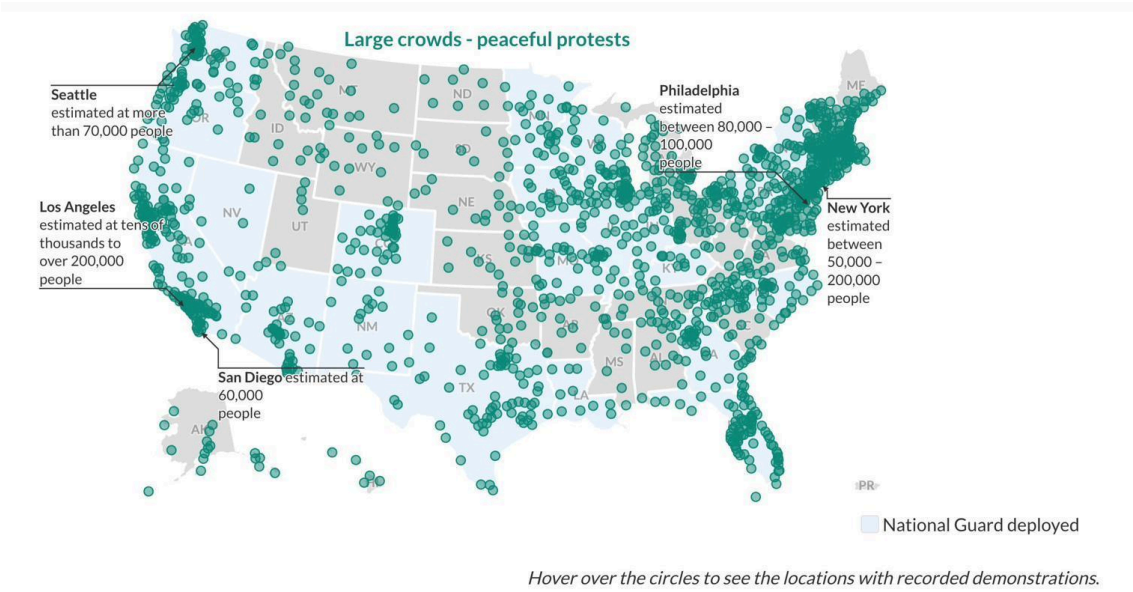


Figure 2. *ACLED map of large peaceful demonstration sites during No Kings I (June 14, 2025). Blue shading indicates states with National Guard deployments. State escalation did not suppress protest but amplified it by reinforcing the movement's executive-overreach narrative. This pattern is examined in later sections through a structuralist account of state–protest feedback dynamics and a constructivist analysis of norm reinforcement (Source: ACLED, 2025).*

Geographically, the protests were both concentrated and widely distributed. As Figure 1 shows, states such as California recorded the highest number of demonstrations, while protests also occurred across all 50 states, including traditionally conservative regions such as Wyoming, South Dakota, and Alabama, indicating broad national reach (ACLED, 2025). In addition, ACLED data indicate that over 99% of events did not involve violence, with fewer than 1% classified as involving clashes or police intervention. Given the scale of mobilization, this reflects a highly disciplined pattern of predominantly nonviolent civic participation (ACLED, 2025).

II. Structural Analysis

Structuralism posits that political behavior is primarily shaped by enduring systemic constraints, including institutional arrangements, class relations, and distributions of power, rather than by the choices or intentions of individual actors (Shively, 2022). The No Kings movement did not arise from isolated individual decisions to protest; it emerged from structural conditions that made large-scale mobilization a predictable outcome. Three key mechanisms can be identified.

Legitimacy Erosion as a Standing Condition

World Values Survey (WVS) Wave 7 data (2017–2020) indicate low confidence in core representative institutions prior to the protests, with roughly three-quarters of respondents expressing a lack of confidence in the federal government. At the same time, about one-third supported strong executive leadership even when it may bypass democratic procedures (WVS, 2020; PBS, 2026). From a structuralist perspective, these distributions point to longer-term perceptions of institutional performance across areas such as healthcare, immigration, and economic security, increasing the likelihood that grievances are expressed through (informal) protest when catalyzed by political events.

Organizational Infrastructure as Structural Capacity

Protest does not arise from grievance alone; it depends on organizational infrastructure, particularly when formal institutional channels are perceived as unresponsive. By early 2025, declining confidence in government had already made civil society organizations the primary vehicles for collective action. Groups such as Indivisible, 50501, MoveOn, the ACLU, and the American Federation of Teachers formed a coalition of more than 200 organizations, enabling coordination across local and national levels. The approximately 500 “Hands Off” protests in

April 2025 demonstrate that this network was operational prior to the emergence of No Kings (Doyle [ACLED], August 2025).

State-Protest Feedback Dynamics

Building on declining institutional trust and pre-existing organizational infrastructure, the "wave" pattern of the No Kings movement can be understood through a structuralist lens as a system-level interaction between state action and protest. As shown in Table 1, national-level government decisions that were widely interpreted as anti-democratic heightened the salience of perceived executive overreach and triggered new waves of mobilization. The October 1, 2025 government shutdown and Operation Midway Blitz, which involved over 1,500 immigration-related arrests, preceded No Kings II (Doyle [ACLED], November 2025), while the onset of the 2026 Iran War preceded No Kings III (Doyle [ACLED], April 2026).

These events didn't act in isolation but interacted with existing grievances and organizational capacity. By reinforcing the movement's core framing of executive overreach, they expanded the pool of potential participants and activated established networks. The result is a reinforcing feedback process in which major government actions catalyze protest, and subsequent mobilization increases the likelihood of further contention. This dynamic produces non-linear escalation across successive waves.

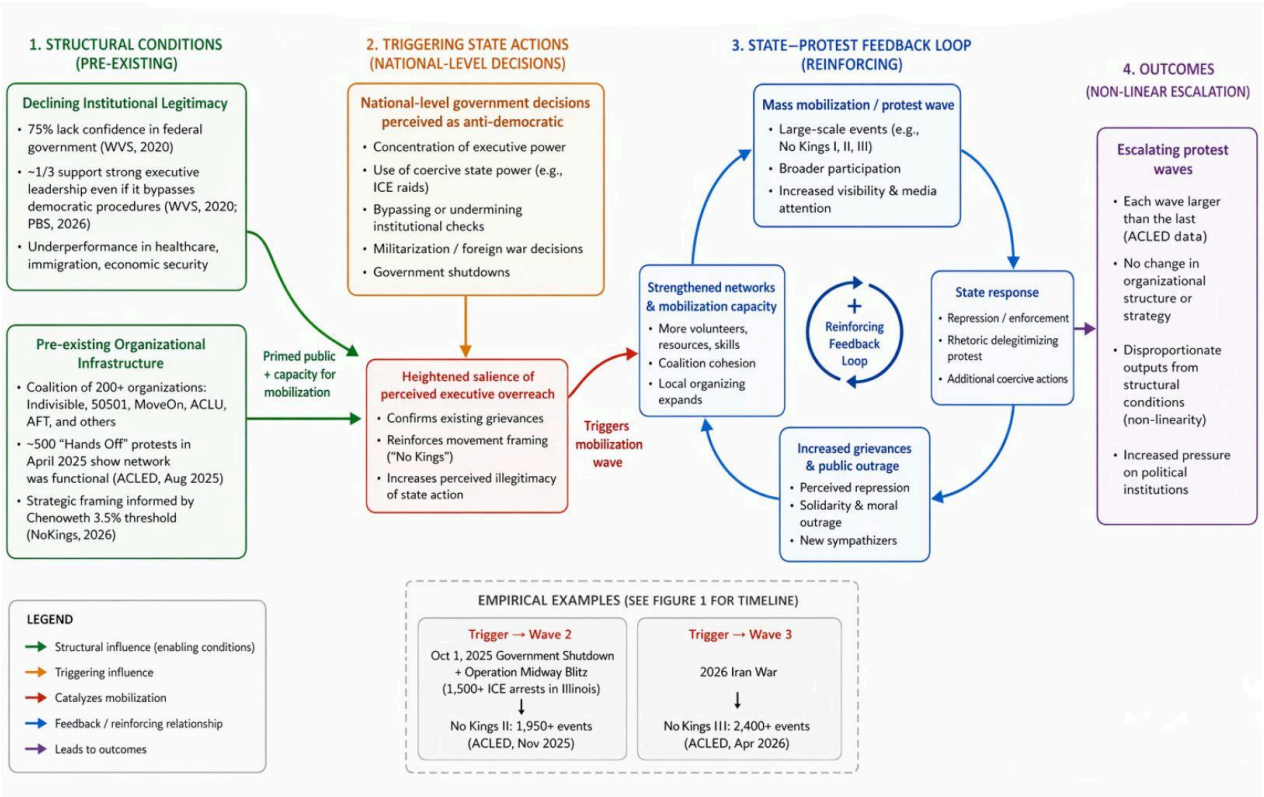


Figure 3. *Structural causal loop diagram of the No Kings movement. This diagram illustrates how pre-existing structural conditions enabled large-scale protest and how subsequent state actions contributed to its escalation. Declining institutional trust and established organizational infrastructure created a population primed for mobilization. National-level government decisions perceived as anti-democratic increased the salience of executive overreach, triggering initial protest waves. These waves then entered a reinforcing state-protest feedback loop, in which state responses generated additional grievances, in turn expanding participation and strengthening mobilization capacity.*

III. Constructivist Analysis

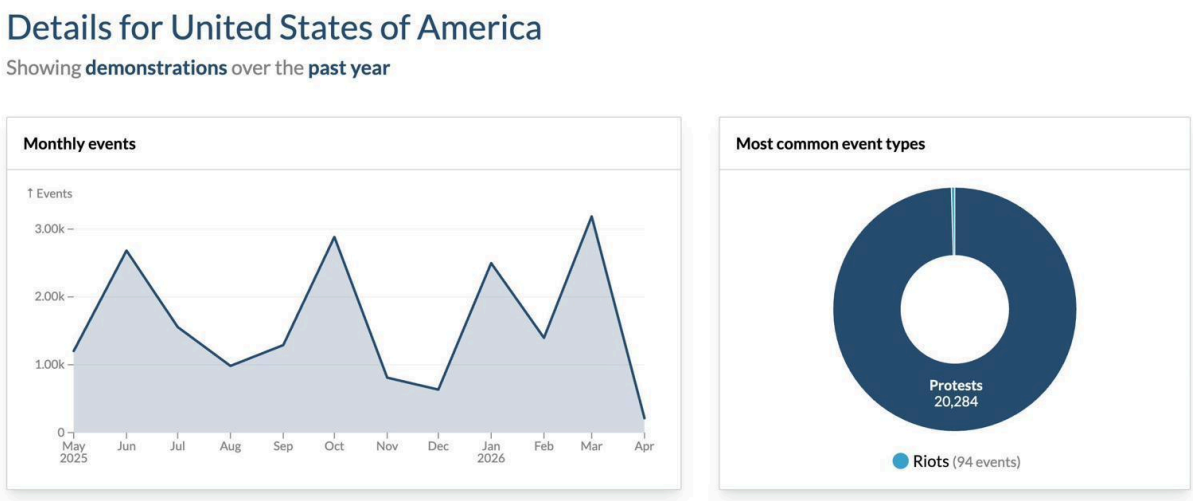


Figure 4. *ACLED monthly demonstration trends for the United States, May 2025-April 2026. Three sharp spikes (June, October, end of March) correspond to the three No Kings waves. (Source: ACLED, 2025)*

As shown in Figure 4, while protests occurred continuously over time, there are three clear spikes in participation corresponding to the major No Kings waves. This pattern of concentrated escalation cannot be explained by structural conditions alone. While structuralism accounts for the material conditions that make protest possible, it doesn't explain why many first-time participants understood their actions as necessary within a specifically democratic, anti-monarchical framework. Constructivist approaches instead emphasize that political behavior is shaped by shared meanings, identities, and narratives that give actions their significance (Finnemore & Sikkink, 1998). In this context, the key question is what collective identity participants adopted and what narrative made participation appear both necessary and legitimate.

Participant testimony shows that individuals framed protest as a civic and moral obligation rather than a policy preference. One protester described participation as continuing a "legacy for social justice…to carry that on in my generation," while another stated that

"democracy is under threat" and that they wanted their "voice to be heard with other people" (CNN, 2026). First-time participants expressed a similar shift from observation to obligation, noting that "when you see things going wrong…it feels good to…speak up" (CNN, 2026). These statements indicate that participation was interpreted as fulfilling a democratic role. Importantly, this role was framed as consistent with defending foundational democratic principles, positioning protest not as rejection of the political system, but as an effort to uphold its core ideals (CNN, 2026).



Figure 5-6. *Photos of the No Kings protests and participant messaging (BBC, 2026; NPR, 2026). These images illustrate both the scale of mass mobilization and the symbolic framing that shaped participation. Large, densely packed crowds demonstrate the movement's capacity for nationwide turnout, while protest signs such as "No Kings" and pro-democracy messaging reflect how participants interpreted their actions through an internalized democratic identity that framed protest as a legitimate and necessary civic act.*

The movement's name, "No Kings," is also central to this identity construction. It operates as a symbolic frame that reinterprets contemporary political conflict through a

historically embedded narrative of resistance to concentrated power. By invoking the founding rejection of monarchy, it collapses diverse grievances into a single, legible claim about illegitimate authority (PBS, 2026). It gives participants a common framework for understanding their actions as part of a broader democratic struggle. "This framing lowers the threshold for participation by simplifying complex issues into a clear moral distinction, linking present action to familiar democratic traditions, and enabling rapid diffusion (PBS, 2026).

Elite responses further illustrate the importance of meaning construction. The White House dismissed the protests as “Trump Derangement Therapy Sessions,” attempting to delegitimize participants (BBC, 2026; CNN, 2026). However, continued mobilization suggests this counter-narrative failed and instead reinforced the movement’s core framing of democratic threat. This reflects norm entrenchment: by failing to delegitimize protest, the administration inadvertently confirmed the movement's framing that democratic norms were under threat, sustaining participation beyond the initial base.

IV. Critical Assessment

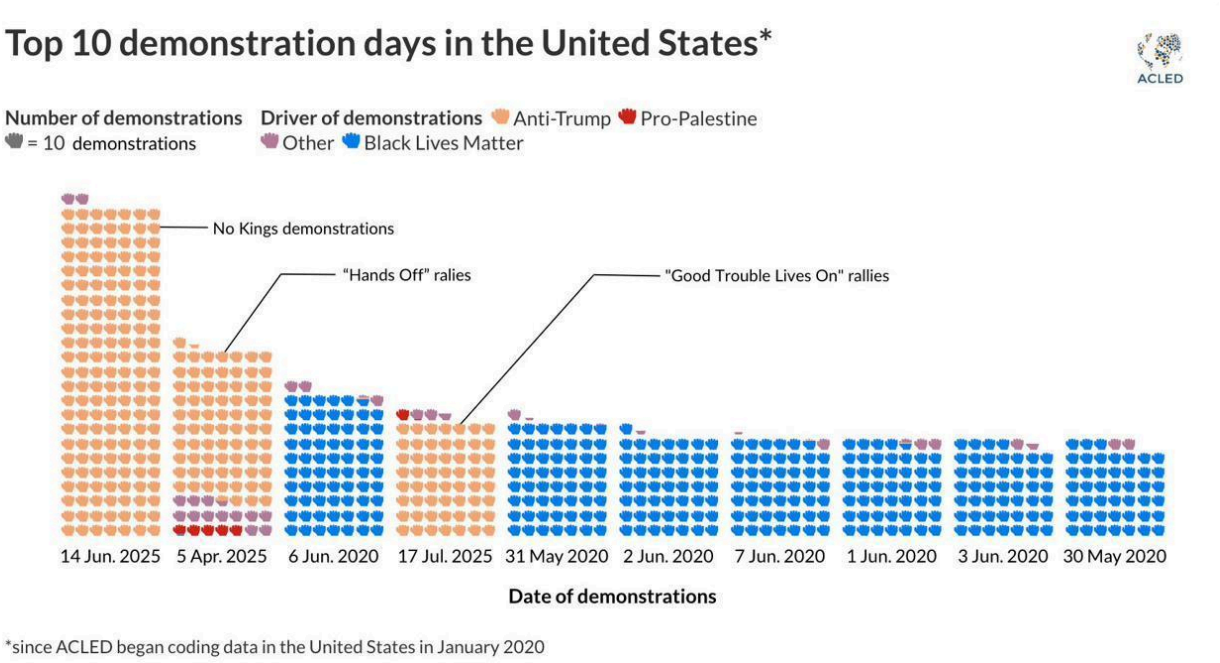


Figure 7. *ACLED top 10 single-day demonstration totals in the United States since 2020. No Kings I–III rank among the largest single-day protest events recorded, exceeding other recent mobilizations. This comparative scale demonstrates the movement's exceptional reach while also serving as the foundations to indicate a gap between protest magnitude and institutional outcomes (ACLED, 2026).*

The Carnegie Endowment for International Peace provides a comparative benchmark, arguing that "mass protest alone is not enough to halt democratic erosion…it must be converted into electoral outcomes or institutional constraints on the executive" (Brechenmacher & Joshi, 2026). On this metric, the No Kings movement is substantial but incomplete. The scale was enabled by a decentralized model that lowered barriers to participation across diverse regions. However, the movement's broad framing as a "national resistance to tyranny," rather than around specific policy demands, facilitated participation while limiting its capacity to produce targeted policy change.

From a systems perspective, this gap is reflected in the dynamics shown in Figure 3. Reinforcing interactions between mobilization, grievances, and organizational capacity produced escalating waves of protest, but, as indicated in Table 1, these have not translated into policy or leadership change. Comparative cases show that success depends on electoral alignment, which remains limited in the U.S. context due to highly partisan participation.[2] Recent shifts toward local advocacy and voter protection ahead of the 2026 midterms suggest a transition from mobilization to organizing. The movement's long-term impact will depend on whether this participation can be converted into sustained electoral and policy outcomes.

V. Conclusion

The No Kings movement's three escalating waves emerged from the convergence of structural preconditions, declining institutional legitimacy, pre-existing organizational infrastructure, and state-protest feedback dynamics and a constructed democratic identity that made participation feel morally necessary across diverse groups. Its historical significance, however, remains contingent. Unprecedented mobilization has not yet produced institutional change, and its long-term impact depends on whether the organizational capacity built across three waves can be converted into electoral outcomes in 2026 and beyond.

Appendix A. Comparative Outcomes of Mass Protest Movements

[2] This is further explored in Appendix A.

This table expands on the comparative framework referenced in Section IV, illustrating how mass protest movements vary in their ability to produce institutional change. Consistent with the Carnegie Endowment analysis, the key differentiating factor across cases is whether protest mobilization is successfully linked to electoral strategies and coalition-building.

Case	Scale of Protest	Political Context	Electoral Alignment	Outcome	Key Mechanism
United States (No Kings, 2025–2026)	~20 million cumulative participants	Democratic system with high polarization and declining trust. Rallying against Trump.	Weak: highly partisan participation with limited cross-party support	No major policy or leadership change to date	Strong mobilization but limited conversion to electoral influence
Poland (2020–2023 protests)	Large-scale nationwide protests (e.g., abortion rights movement)	Democratic backsliding with competitive elections	Strong: opposition parties coordinated and targeted key voter groups	Electoral turnover and policy shifts	Mobilization linked to voter turnout campaigns and opposition alignment
Brazil (2022 protests)	Mass protests against democratic erosion and coup threats	Competitive electoral system under strain	Strong: broad coalitions across ideological groups	Electoral defeat of incumbent leadership	Coalition-building and alignment with viable electoral alternative
Georgia (2023–2024 protests)	Sustained mass protests in urban centers	Hybrid regime with increasing repression	Weak: fragmented opposition and limited electoral coordination	No significant institutional change	Failure to translate protest into electoral leverage

South Korea (2024–2025 protests)	Large-scale protests following executive overreach (martial law attempt)	Democratic system with lower polarization on core issue	Strong: broad cross-partisan public support	Impeachment of president	High public consensus enabling institutional response

Analytical Summary

Across cases, protest scale alone does not determine outcomes. Instead, institutional impact depends on whether mobilization shifts the balance of political power through electoral alignment. Cases such as Poland, Brazil, and South Korea demonstrate that when protest movements build broad coalitions and connect to viable electoral alternatives, they can produce policy or leadership change. In contrast, cases such as Georgia and the United States illustrate that even large-scale mobilization may fail to generate institutional outcomes when participation remains fragmented or highly partisan.

This comparison supports the argument in Section IV: the No Kings movement has achieved exceptional mobilization, but its long-term impact will depend on whether it can transition from protest to sustained electoral and organizational engagement.

Appendix B. AI Statement

This assignment was done with the assistance of Claude (Anthropic) as a research and drafting support tool, in accordance with Minerva's AI use policy. AI was used to help locate and synthesize relevant sources, including ACLED, Carnegie, and WVS materials, and to support the organization and structuring of the argument. All analytical claims, interpretations, and final written content are my own, and all sources were verified against original materials (all sources were found by me, AI was used to help analyze and store those sources). Spelling and grammar were reviewed using Grammarly, and citations were formatted using MyBib.

Appendix C: LO and HC Justifications

Table C1. LOs Addressed

LO	Application
#poliscimethods	The paper combines quantitative event data (ACLED protest counts, geographic distribution, violence classification rates) with qualitative sources (CNN testimony, Carnegie comparative analysis, PBS historical context) in an explicitly mixed-methods case study design. The causal loop diagram (Figure 3) constitutes an original visualization translating ACLED data into a theoretical model. The WVS Wave 7 survey data (attitudinal frequencies on institutional confidence) are cited as empirical baselines. This methodological pluralism is itself named and justified in the analysis: structuralism requires material/quantitative indicators, constructivism requires interpretive/qualitative evidence.
#casestudy	The paper uses the United States (2025–2026) as a bounded historical case study, structured around a clear research question (why did No Kings emerge in three escalating waves and how did it scale?). The Carnegie Endowment's comparative framework, drawing on South Korea, Poland, Brazil, Georgia, and Serbia, is used to benchmark the U.S. case against analogous instances of mass mobilization under democratic backsliding. This structured comparison isolates the electoral-conversion variable as the key differentiator between movements that achieved institutional impact and those that did not, following the logic of comparative case analysis. The timeline table (Table 1) explicitly operationalizes the case's temporal boundaries and key events.

LO	Application
#ss112-constructivism	Section III applies constructivism to explain why structural conditions alone cannot account for the movement's specific form. Protester testimony (CNN, 2026) is analyzed as evidence of intersubjective meaning-making: participants framed protest as civic obligation rather than policy preference. The movement's name is interpreted as a symbolic frame invoking the founding rejection of monarchy, collapsing diverse grievances into a single legible claim. The White House counter-narrative is analyzed through norm entrenchment: its failure to suppress mobilization demonstrates that protest had become widely understood as legitimate civic action.
#ss112-integratingtheories	The paper explicitly integrates structuralism and constructivism as distinct but complementary lenses applied to the same empirical phenomenon. The integration is methodologically justified: structuralism explains the necessary preconditions (legitimacy erosion, organizational capacity, feedback loops) that made large-scale protest possible, while constructivism explains the specific ideational form the movement took (democratic identity frame, anti-monarchical narrative) and why that form achieved resonance across diverse groups. Section IV synthesizes both: the structural analysis explains the three-wave escalation pattern, the constructivist analysis explains sustained participation, and the critical assessment evaluates both against the Carnegie comparative benchmark for institutional impact.
#ss112-structuralism	Section II identifies three structural mechanisms driving the movement: (1) legitimacy erosion as a standing condition, evidenced by WVS Wave 7 data showing roughly

LO	Application
	three-quarters of U.S. respondents lacked confidence in the federal government; (2) pre-existing organizational infrastructure, evidenced by the coalition of 200+ organizations (Indivisible, 50501, MoveOn, ACLU, AFT) that had already demonstrated operational capacity through ~500 Hands Off protests in April 2025; and (3) a reinforcing state-protest feedback loop in which major government actions (the government shutdown, Operation Midway Blitz, the Iran War) catalyzed successive protest waves. The causal loop diagram (Figure 3) visualizes these mechanisms explicitly.

Table C2. HC Addressed

HC	Application
#systemmapping	Section II identifies a reinforcing feedback loop as the structural driver of the movement's escalation. State actions such as ICE raids, National Guard deployments, the government shutdown, and the Iran War increased grievances, which expanded the pool of potential participants, strengthened organizational capacity, and amplified subsequent protest waves. This dynamic explains the non-linear growth from approximately 4-6 million participants in No Kings I (1,600+ events), to around 7 million in No Kings II (1,950+ events), and roughly 8 million in No Kings III (2,400+ events), despite no significant change in organizational strategy.
#complexcausality	The paper's central argument is explicitly multi-causal. Section I distinguishes structural preconditions (declining institutional trust documented in WVS Wave 7, organizational infrastructure in place by April 2025) from proximate triggering events (the June 14, 2025

HC	Application
	military parade, ICE raids). Section III adds a third causal layer: the constructed democratic identity frame that made participation feel morally necessary. Neither structural conditions, nor triggering events, nor framing alone explains the movement; all three are necessary.
#emergentproperties	No Kings emerged from the decentralized interaction of 200+ civil society organizations, and pre-existing civic infrastructure. The result; 8 million participants across 3,300 sites in 50 states by March 28th, 2026; was not planned or directed by any single actor but arose from distributed coordination. No single organization could have achieved this scale independently. The movement's geographic reach into traditionally conservative states (Wyoming, South Dakota, Alabama) and its (later) extension to 15 countries were emergent outcomes of the decentralized model, not intended design features.

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